

FROM ROUGH AND TUMBLE OF FOOTBALL TO PEOPLE'S CHAMPION

For Norwegian and Punjab FC forward Mushaga Bakenga, football has always been the **cornerstone** of his life. To him, it's not just a game but a tool for a greater purpose.

Jonathan Selvaraj

jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

In 2018, Mushaga Bakenga, who last represented Norway in 2014, believed his footballing career had come to an end. At just 26, he had been battling a series of injuries, the most recent being a ruptured Achilles tendon in his foot, which required surgery. Only a year earlier, he had undergone the same procedure.

Just before he was ready to call time on his career, his mother's eldest brother asked to meet him. Of course, Bakenga agreed. This was not just any visit, and his uncle was no ordinary relative.

Denis Mukwege, a pastor and gynaecologist, founded the Panzi Hospital in the city of Bukavu in Eastern Congo. There, he specialises in treating women who have been raped by armed rebels during the brutal civil wars that

New addition: Punjab FC signed Norwegian forward Mushaga Bakenga ahead of the ISL 2024-25 season. FSDL/FOCUS SPORTS